

Android Auto vs. Apple CarPlay: The grand showdown

With the rising number of smartphones in the world and almost every carmaker opting for its own custom infotainment console, the need for unified infotainment platforms became crucial. Enter, Apple CarPlay and Android Auto, bringing essentials of iOS and Android to cars. While this sounds good and each has its strengths, they're not quite perfect, yet.

Apple CarPlay

Connecting with Apple CarPlay is much simpler - plug in your Lightning cable to the USB deck here, and tap on Apple CarPlay on your central touchscreen unit to activate it.

CarPlay is also smoother and more responsive than Android Auto, just like the persistent difference between iOS and Android, and it also connects more swiftly. The interface is typically iOS and aids familiarity, but app support for India is very limited.

All of this leaves a gaping absence in India. The Apple CarPlay ecosystem does not support Google Maps, and Apple

up, despite being responsive and swift, Apple CarPlay is extremely restricted in India. You can essentially only make calls, hear up to the last 10 received messages and play your music. Most cars right now already support calling and music from phones via Bluetooth (even without GUIs), and seeing how much of your personal conversations are held via WhatsApp and Messenger nowadays, it is practically only a cosmetic presence in your car, and not really functional.

Android Auto

To connect Android Auto, connect your phone via Bluetooth with the system, then plug it in via USB. Prior to this, download Android Auto from the Play Store. Once you are paired with Bluetooth, connecting your phone and switching on Android Auto from both the phone and the infotainment unit initialises a first-time setup, followed by a short tutorial and finally, the home screen. In comparison, all you do for Apple CarPlay with iPhones is connect via USB and tap on Apple CarPlay from the head unit. See the difference?

That said, Android Auto looks more lively, albeit slightly low resolution. It is slower than CarPlay, and every app displays lag while opening. It is here that Apple CarPlay outdoes Android Auto, fair and square.

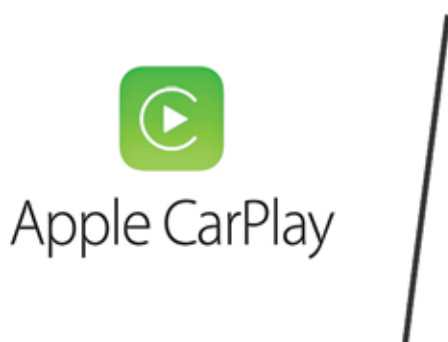
However, Android Auto is the more useful of the two. You get access to your contacts and recent numbers, which you can tap on or use OK Google to access. Like CarPlay, Android Auto does not let you really read messages, and all operations are via voice. Against CarPlay's SMS/iMessage support, Android Auto supports apps like WhatsApp, WeChat, Google Hangouts and Telegram (FB Messenger misses out). This makes it more useful than CarPlay, covering more essentials.

The biggest boon, however, is Google Maps. It works as well as it does on any phone, and you get comprehensive route details including traffic, and this hands Android Auto a major advantage over Apple CarPlay.

Music playback allows local music sync and streaming via Google Play Music, but the playlist sync is erratic. After a few attempts, though, it gets the job done.

Our verdict

Despite the cleaner and faster interface on CarPlay, it is Android Auto that proves to be better equipped in features for now. It provides third party messaging support, Google Maps and music playback along with calling and 'OK Google' voice assistance, making it the better option of the two for India right now. 



Maps is not supported in India's versions of CarPlay, at least for now. As a result, if you would need navigation while using Apple CarPlay, you would need to separately use Google Maps (or any other navigation app) from your iPhone or use the infotainment system's default satellite navigation.

Most inputs are handled by Siri, and this makes it fairly easy to make calls on the go. However, you can only see the list of the last 10 messages received and have them read out (no visual text for safety). It would have been more proficient if there were speed-sensing restrictions, so that the driver could have accessed messages on the screen whenever the car stopped moving.

Apple Music works as intended, but there is no keyboard input to search for new songs (you rely on Siri here). To sum